minutes', was identified as the reason for the draining of RFNA.

The findings were presented to Prof. Dhawan at a meeting of top ISRO scientists and were accepted. Everybody was convinced by the technical cause-and-effect sequence presented and there was a general feeling of satisfaction about the whole exercise of failure-management measures taken. I was stil unconvinced though and felt restless. To me, the level of responsibility is measured by one's ability to confront the decision-making process without any delay or distraction.

On the spur of the moment, I stood up and addressed Prof. Dhawan, "Sir, even though my friends have technical y justified the failure, I take the responsibility for judging the RFNA leak detected during the final phase of countdown as insignificant. As a Mission Director, I should have put the launch on hold and saved the flight if possible. In a similar situation abroad, the Mission Director would have lost his job. I therefore take responsibility for the SLV-3 failure." For quite some time there was pin-drop silence in the hal . Then Prof. Dhawan got up and said, "I am going to put Kalam in orbit!", and left the place signal ing that the meeting was